demand that I wore clothing that suited the gravity of the occasion. Imagine me sitting in a hot poky flat in Paris, unshaven, typing away, but wearing exactly the right sort of jacket. I know.

Daniel Mathews stayed on board as long as he could but he started to burn out with the lack of rewards. By this time he had moved to Stanford, where he was completing his PhD and teaching at the same time. It wasn't even, at that point, as if we were getting a lot of positive feedback from the community. There's wasn't any sense of us gaining an uplift in our popular reputation on the back of all the hard work: the volunteers must have asked themselves, as they probably still do, what was in it for them and at the time I had no answer to that. I was just intent on doing it and I hoped other people would find a deep source of motivation in the work itself. It all got pretty difficult at several moments. It wasn't human, the amount of work in front of us in 2007, the intensity, the pressure. I went to Africa during that time and came back to Paris with good connections, but I wasn't feeling well. After a while it turned into a fever and there was a sudden spike in my temperature. As you'll have gathered, I'm a bit of a know-all – one of those vices that can quite often be turned into a virtue – so of course I've read a few medical textbooks and I'm extremely sceptical of doctors. The fever was bad, but I felt certain it would burn itself out in a few days. After ten days or so of sweating and suffering, it wasn't getting any better.

I had malaria. Spending time in a French hospital can make you understand why there was, and always will be, a need in that country for revolution. A short visit, even, can make you see why Flaubert hated the bourgeoisie and why the '60s radicals wanted to burn down the Sorbonne. Not that I came out of it very well, either. The nurse who was looking after me had the demeanour of a natural bully. She tried to put paracetamol in my arm. I said I wasn't in pain and didn't need it. She said they gave it to all the patients, no matter what. I said no. She tried to stick it in during the night and I refused and she tried again, so I ripped it out and said if she kept it up I would walk out of the hospital. I know, I know, who would go to war with a nurse? But, I'm telling you, these nurses are fascistic, and I was ill with fever so I was a bit off my head anyway. And this old man who was sharing the room with me was cheering me on, saying the nurses were always trying to push you around. He loved this display of resistance to the nursing staff. They just couldn't deal with me because I wouldn't take paracetamol. And when I later got a stomach cramp they wouldn't bring a doctor,